key issues in society as what constitutes ethical conduct; how a just society is made and sustained; and the duties and obligations of kings, counsellors, warriors, women and sages. They deal with great moral dilemmas and issues of right conduct, justice and fidelity, violence and redemption; they give voice to a range of actors and concerns; they provide models for social and political action; and because they are told and retold as stories, they have embedded themselves in the popular consciousness of Hindus.

The *Ramayana*, the epic tale of an exiled prince's conquest of the demon kingdom where his wife is held hostage, is a stirring saga, intimately familiar to all Indians and most Southeast Asians. Lord Rama's ultimate triumph and his return to rule his own kingdom as a just and benevolent king is the archetypal story of the victory of good over evil; yet in many of its episodes, including what becomes of his queen, there are complex moral dilemmas unveiled that do not lend themselves to simplistic interpretations.

The *Mahabharata* deals much more with *adharma*: it is a tale of the real world, one whose heroes have feet of clay, whose stories have ambiguous ends, whose events range from great feats of honour and valour to dubious compromises, broken promises, dishonourable battles, expedient lies, dispensable morality. It asks profound questions about the nature of *dharma*: Yudhishthira says 'dharma is subtle' and each episode in the epic appears to be a case study of what this means—is *dharma* derived from the *shastra*s, from precedents, from *nyay*, from *niti*? Is it determined by caste or gender? The *Mahabharata* offers much ground for reflection on weighty ethical and moral dilemmas. When the low-born Ekalavya becomes a master archer by eavesdropping on lessons offered by Dronacharya to his caste betters, the teacher asks for the boy's thumb in tribute, which would destroy his ability to practise what he has learned. When Draupadi, wife of the Pandavas, is 'lost' in a wager in a fixed game of dice, she questions the right of her husband to stake her and the propriety of the winners to seize her. By raising these questions, the epic obliges Hindus to interrogate themselves about their beliefs. The *Mahabharata* has come to stand for so much in the popular consciousness of Indians: the issues the epic raises, as well as the values